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Léa

Léa put the contract on her lap and looked out the window as the train rattled to a stop. A sign on the platform said *Metz*.

The station's massive fortress-like façade loomed over the platform, casting sharp shadows that seemed to swallow the sunlight. Léa remembered the day all the typists in Maître Mallon's office gathered around a newspaper reading the headlines that announced Germany had annexed Metz and other cities on the eastern part of France. From all the German language signs and the red and black banners adorned with swastikas, Léa could see that the Germans had done their best to stamp out all forms of French life.

"Where are we?" Rose awakened, rubbing her eyes.

"We're in Germany," Léa said, glancing at the guard who'd accompanied them from Orléans. He sat at the far end of the carriage—uniform immaculate, posture rigid—he kept his eyes coldly on them. "I know where we're going," she said, pointing at the contract in her lap.

Rose sat upright. "Tell me."

"Our employment contract is with the Archimedes Company."

"Arc-chi-me-what?" Rose yawned.

Léa repeated the name. "They make calculating machines."

Rose's face went blank. "What's a calculating machine?"

"Maybe it's like a typewriter for numbers," Léa said.

Rose leaned forward, but Léa could see she was more interested in the scenery outside than in calculating machines or the terms of their contract.

"How can this be a train station?" she asked. "It feels like a church. Look at the clock tower." She pulled out her notepad and began sketching